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Chazz Frichtel

Chazz Frichtel is multi-talented songwriter, vocalist, guitarist and bassist. He was born in Prospect, N.Y. and relocated to Los Angeles in the late 70s. He has played bass and toured with a long list of diverse artists including Michael McDonald, Chuck Mangione, Chaka Kahn and Christopher Cross. Chazz sang the theme song for the syndicated television series "Saved by the Bell" and his versatility enabled a rich career in the competitive music business.

Chazz was interviewed in Clinton, NY on June 13, 2016 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. And a fortuitous meeting yesterday leads me to an interview with my old friend Chazz Frichtel. And that was quite an odd thing for us to come together after — I tried to count the years and I gave up.

CF: I know. It's been a long, long time, but fortuitous, absolutely. It's great to see you.

MR: When you meet someone for the first time and they say, "so what do you do" — do you have a short answer?

CF: I have a short answer. I say I'm a musician. And then they go, "but what do you really do." And I say I'm a musician. And I understand it. Because the music business, it might not be the easiest way to make a living. And a lot of people I think have done it either semi-professionally or where they have a regular day gig or something like that. And I feel incredibly fortunate to have been able to make my living my adult life as a professional musician — either as a player or singing or a composer. It's been wonderful. Challenging often times, but wonderful.

MR: Your income curve can —

CF: Can fluctuate weekly.

MR: Yes. Forget about what was my income last year, what was it last week.

CF: Exactly. That's exactly right.

MR: I'm assuming that you have to be fairly versatile.

CF: Yeah. Yeah. It's amazing. The L.A. music scene is probably — because of TV and film a little bit more popular music oriented than say New York or the jazz scene in New York, although there's a vibrant jazz scene in L.A. But yeah, you pretty much have to be able to understand a lot of different genres of music, especially if you're going in as a studio player and have the skills needed for session work, which is being able to read and understand and decipher a chart and those kind of things, but understanding different styles of music, whether it's rock or Latin music or film cues, things like that. So versatility is important. It's important.

MR: So you are predominantly a bassist and a singer, and you also are a songwriter. I've seen you playing guitar on the internet. All those things together, if you look at your week, a typical week now or 20 years ago, what was a typical week like for you?

CF: Well a typical week, it all depends on what years we're talking about. When I first got to L.A. in the late 70s, actually most of my career I've spent probably the most time playing the bass and singing. That's what I got hired for and that's what I kind of built my reputation on. But all along the way I've also played guitar and I play piano a little bit, enough to accompany myself. I would never book myself as a guitarist per se, but I kind of played James Taylor style, that kind of thing. But a typical week used to be generally on the weekends there'd be like private functions. One of the great things in L.A., when I first got there there was a lot of live music happening in the clubs and there was also a lot of live playing going on which in New York they call club dates and out there we call casuals. And they would be private functions in Beverly Hills or Bel Air or around town. And what was great about that was that you could wind up on a gig and all of a sudden in walks Ernie Watts or some other guys from *The Tonight Show* band and you're like, "wow, that's Ernie Watts." And so we did that kind of work, there were lots of sessions going on, people needing tracks for their demos, we did some prerecord things for Vegas shows, it was busy. And then I was always — always had kind of an original band going so we were always in the studio cutting tracks and trying to get some kind of deal going, which eventually almost led to near-bankruptcy.

MR: We might as well — we can go there now. Because right on my page here I have "record labels." And I wanted to ask what that was like because in the 80s I was in a band that was trying for that. There's this term that we I think probably you've used too in the back of your mind like, "I want to make it big." "I want to make it in the music business." And it used to be all right, you have to hook up with a record label.

CF: Right, right. Well that used to be true. And certainly still in the late 70s when I got there and into the early 80s that was true. And it's funny because I really went to L.A., I didn't really have any interest in becoming a session player or a touring musician. I wanted to be part of a creative force, be part of a band. And I wanted to be involved in, hopefully, the writing, the singing and the playing — whether it was bass guitar or whatever. But that was my central focus. And it was only out of really necessity after years of trying to get record label interest in these various projects that I kind of went man, this is not quite working as I had hoped. And then fortunately things started coming, session work was coming and touring work, and I was able to survive as a working musician, which at that point I was really thrilled about. And I've always been thrilled about. So I kind of put that group thing, at one point it was just financially I had to move it over here and then kind of go over here to survive.

MR: Were your bandmates experiencing the same kind of situation?

CF: Yeah. Absolutely. And one of the reasons these bands were so tough to keep together, the players were good and they were being offered touring gigs and they were being offered other things. So keeping a working entity together was tough because there were all these other offers coming in and that just kind of added to the equation of like doing a band was really, really hard.

MR: We went to L.A., it was over 20 years ago, and we went to the Baked Potato, and the people that were playing there were incredible. And somehow I guess I learned that they were playing for like $30 apiece if that.

CF: Absolutely. Absolutely. Yeah I played at the Baked Potato many times. It's considered kind of a jazz fusion room, and it's a place you don't want to see in the daylight. It's pretty funky in there. But it was an L.A. institution as far as, I mean you could go there and you could see all the top session guys, and it was started by one of the guys that was in *The Wrecking Crew*, Don Randi, it's basically his club. But I saw a lot of great music out there, and played there a bunch of times over the years. But there was never much money involved. You know, that's for sure.

MR: Did your parents think — what did your parents think of you moving to the other coast?

CF: My mom was all for it. She was the musician in the family and she knew that I had a real passion for it and fortunately she passed her talent on to me. And I think my dad was a little apprehensive. You know, he was a GE engineer guy. And when I first got to L.A. the first year was pretty tough going. I mean some not so fun things happened the first year I was there. But all of that eventually led to kind of my first break, which was two weeks — it was either a week or two weeks in Lake Tahoe with Racquel Welch. And my dad actually flew out to see that show, I wonder why. I'm not so sure it was to see me. But I think at that point he kind of breathed a sigh of relief and I think he became kind of one of my biggest fans and supporters.

MR: That's great.

CF: He told me before he passed, he said, "I really admire your bravery and your stick-to-it-iveness" if there is such a word.

MR: Were you nervous on that first gig with her? Do you remember?

CF: I don't know — if I was nervous it was more excitement. Her act was more of a cabaret kind of act. But it was kind of one of my first encounters with celebrity and of course I couldn't look at her without seeing the 2000 B.C. poster that a lot of us had. But she was very nice and she made me feel welcome and at ease and she was really fun to work with.

MR: It's funny you say that because Aretha Franklin played here once and I got to play in the horn section.

CF: Nice.

MR: And we couldn't afford to like watch her because if you started watching her you'd forget to play. And the conductor's doing all these things and it's just like how do you tune out Aretha Franklin?

CF: Yeah. No that was great, and I think that sort of put my dad's apprehension aside.

MR: So one thing leads to another out there?

CF: Yeah, yeah. It's amazing because a lot of the casual work that I did led to — that was the best way to network. Because you would meet new players on each gig and then you would kind of start to build a reputation that is well this guy knows tunes, he can play different kinds of things, he can rock out, so that was really kind of how I built my career initially was through doing these casuals. And wonderful players on the gigs. I mean all the guys and everybody could play.

MR: Did you meet those kind of studio guys who, they'd have a date from 10 to 2 and then they'd have a date from 2 to 5 somewhere else and they're just trying to get from one place to the other.

CF: Yeah absolutely. When I first got there, one of the first people I called, because I admired her so much, was Carol Kaye. And she was mostly teaching then, because the days of *The Wrecking Crew* had kind of given way to bands as opposed to hiring this incredible section of musicians that played on everything. But she was doing a lot of teaching. And she used to tell me about what her schedule was like in the day, and she'd have a ten o'clock call at Capitol and then she'd have a one o'clock call over at Emerald or another studio. And this was like five days a week. And she had an amazing career. Tommy Tedesco, all those people in *The Wrecking Crew,* they worked nonstop.

MR: I'm going to move your mic up a little bit and we'll just edit this out. These things are so sensitive that they — see if that's better.

So you say, "Hey Carol, if you can't make a date here I am, right?"

CF: Yeah, exactly. She was great. She tried to get me to play with a pick, which I never — she really loved playing with a pick. Because she was actually an excellent jazz guitar player. I don't think a lot of people know that about her. And another thing that was kind of cool too is she impressed upon me how most of the people that were in *The Wrecking Crew* were jazz players. They wanted to play jazz. But they started getting all this studio work and cha-chang. You know. The money was coming in.

MR: That's interesting you say that because I think the same thing was happening in New York. The other day for instance, I learned that Milt Hinton and Bucky Pizzarelli both played on Del Shannon's "The Wanderer."

CF:: Unreal.

MR: And those guys just did that, day after day.

CF: Yeah. Well you know you've got to keep the lights on.

MR: And it's cool because a rock, a good rock player I don't think could go in and play a jazz date, nor can a classical person go in and play a rock date. So you have to give credit to the jazz guys.

CF: Yeah absolutely. I think that's true. I think it's easier to come from a jazz background and adapt to a pop format than it is the other way around.

MR: So you've played with some great people. Did you have to official "audition" for instance to get with Michael MacDonald?

CF: No. No, that, there's a little story to that. I was introduced — well I was recommended to Michael by Christopher Cross. And I had played one gig with Christopher, it wasn't even his gig, it was a showcase at a club in Santa Monica called At My Place. And Christopher ended up being the guitar player in the band for my friend who was showcasing, whose name was Karen Blake, a great singer. I had worked with Karen in a little female trio called Souvenir. And she wanted to do a showcase and try and get her solo artist thing going. And I almost didn't take the gig because she said, "Oh man, I can't pay you anything" and "we're going to need a bunch of rehearsals." And I thought I don't know. And then I thought she's a friend. Come on. So I show up at rehearsal and she says, "I want you to meet my friend, Christopher Cross." And this was when Christopher was riding high. You know, with that big album.

MR: "Sailing."

CF: "Sailing," and "Say You'll Be Mine" and all those tunes. And I was kind of like wow, this is cool. And then she said, "oh and I want you to meet another friend of mine, Karla Bonoff." And Karla was singing background. So I was like wow, cool. But we went on and we rehearsed and we played the gig and I didn't think a thing of it. You know? That was it. And then maybe several months later I come home one day and I check the machine and it's like, "um this is Mike MacDonald, Christopher Cross suggested I should call you. Could you give me a call back?" And I did and he was looking for someone to sub for his bass player, a guy named George Hawkins, who had some conflicts with Boz Scaggs. So you know, Michael is really a modest guy and he goes, "well I don't know if you'd be into doing it or not," and meanwhile I'm trying to keep my cool on the phone you know. And when I first heard the message on the machine I called a couple of friends and said, "Hey are you pranking me on this?" I didn't believe it. And so that's kind of how that came about. So the power of yes. You know I almost said no. And then I thought come on, she's a friend. It's a no-brainer. Let's do this. So it was very fortuitous.

MR: So you did some rehearsing with him or did you just like do gigs?

CF: With Michael?

MR: Yeah.

CF: No, we had, I think we had, well I got a cassette of a live show so I went to the woodshed with that. And then I think we had two or three days of rehearsal with the full band out at a place called The Power Plant, which was a big rehearsal facility. And the first gig I did with him was at the Delmar Racetrack down towards San Diego. And I've got to say, man, it was a night I will never forget. A) I've never played — up to that point I don't think I'd played in a band that was quite that loud. But it was super musical. David Pack from Ambrosia was the guitar player at the time, and Vince Denham was our woodwind player, Scott Plunkett was playing keyboards, my good friend George Perilli who we ended up playing for years. He was from Pittsburgh. Great drummer. And a guy that grew up with Mike in St. Louis, Chuck Sabatino, who has since passed — the only guy to this day who can go toe to toe vocally with Michael. And he was in the band so it was fantastic. It was great. It was a fun night, the first night of almost 20 years of nights.

MR: Now do those type of guys use different players in the studio than they do live?

CF: Yeah. Usually. Although I did some session work with Mike but normally that call — it seems like it comes down to the producer, and the producer calls his guys, and I think Ted Templeman was producing Mike at that point. And I've got to say though, that was a little bit of a tough pill to swallow, only because I felt like certainly the guys in the touring band were capable of recording, but I don't think it was really Mike's call because the producers control the money and — but Mike was kind of, we got in there on a few tunes that's documented. That's great.

MR: Yeah I know what you mean by loud. Because I've played in some loud bands and that can be —

CF: Yeah, there were times when I would walk over by Mike's monitors, and it was like a certain frequency would come out and it was like somebody just punched you in the face. You'd step back and immediately leave the zone. But it was a great band. Every incarnation of the band over those almost 20 years, we had great people in the band. And Mike is a super nice guy, easy to work with, unaffected, really a good dude.

MR: Tell me about Chuck Mangione. Because I got to know him when I was in Rochester as a kid. But that was before he was Chuck Mangione, he was just Chuck Mangione.

CF: Well I started working with Chuck in 2000. And like you, I mean before he broke nationally he was kind of a regional star here with the "Friends and Love" recording. And I loved his music. Never in my wildest dreams did I think that our paths would ever cross all these years later. But I had moved to Nashville in '97 because I wanted to check out the songwriting scene and Mike had moved to Nashville and our drummer George Perilli had moved there. And I kind of wanted to take a break from the L.A. treadmill that I was on. And I really wanted to indulge my songwriting. And everybody said it's a great songwriter's town, which it is. But I was there and I was still touring with Michael and I

was kind of indulging the songwriting thing, and I got a call from Chuck's manager, a guy named Richard Burkhart asking me if I was interested. And apparently a guy that I knew in L.A., a bass player named Charles Meeks, who had played with Chuck forever, great Charles, lovely guy, great player, played on all the hits, "Feels So Good" and he decided to retire. And I knew Grant Geissman and I'd played with Grant quite a bit in L.A. He was Chuck's guitar player, played the famous solo on "Feels So Good." And so apparently through I think Rick Montalbano recommended me to Chuck. Because they'd been playing together a little bit at The Savoy. And Rick mentioned me to Chuck and then I think Rick said, "Yeah I know this guy, he's living in Nashville." And I think Chuck went [sneers] "Nashville." But then Chuck — as I understand it — called Grant and said, "oh yeah man, I know Chazz, he'd be great for the band." And next thing I knew I was in New York and we were at SIR playing. And the first couple of gigs I did with Chuck, Ricky was playing, which, Ricky is one of my mentors and dearest friends. So that was a great thrill to be able to connect again.

MR: SIR was a studio?

CF: Yes, in New York. Studio Instrument Rental rehearsal space.

MR: And did he have like chord charts or did he have lines for you?

CF: It was a combination of both. He had certain things that were very specific parts, but most of the tunes were kind of basic chord charts with certain lines written in. And what was great about that gig for me was that after all these years of playing in more of a pop — with singers per se. With Chuck's band you had to understand bebop, Latin, we did certain orchestra dates so you had to kind of be able to play the orchestra book. And for me it was a blowing gig. There were several bass features and I started — I took over, Charles was the singer — Charles Meeks was the singer, so I kind of took over the singing role as well. And it was really fun. And before I did that gig I really did a lot of shedding because I thought wow, it required more from me than a lot of the other gigs had. And it was really, really fun, really fun. And it was a different vocabulary, different sensibility, new jokes, you know. It was wonderful.

MR: New countries to play in?

CF: Yeah. And opportunities to play in places that I hadn't had with some of the other acts. Like we got to play the Clifford Brown Jazz Fest in Delaware, the Newport Jazz Fest, more of the jazz-oriented festivals. The Blue Notes in Italy and New York. And it was a different thing. And it was the right thing for me at the right time. So I didn't leave Mike's band to exclusively go with Chuck but I had been there a long time and I knew if I wanted to grow I should go do this. And it was wonderful.

MR: He's a controversial figure. Some people think he was like the Kenny G of his day. But he wrote such great hooks.

CF: Yeah. I think his greatest strength was exactly what you just touched on. The melodies and the music to me personally were deeper than the modern day smooth jazzers. And I just thought he had a wonderful sense of melody and harmony and of course he's a wonderful flugelhornist himself and hey, he played with Art Blakey you know. And he and Gerry Niewood had a special thing. I mean growing up together and playing all those years that they had together. I was lucky enough to play most of the time Gerry was there, but when he wasn't there Chris Vadala was there. And we had a great band. It was really great. At first Grant was still doing some of the gigs, Grant Geissman, and then we got a wonderful young guitarist who became one of my dearest friends, a guy named Coleman Mellett who sadly he and Gerry were killed when —

MR: The plane went down.

CF: The flight went down outside of Buffalo. But we had great bands. And I finally, after hearing this guy on record and hearing about him from Carmen and Ricky, I finally got to meet Don Alias. Because Don was in the band. And Don and I became fast friends, I think mostly because I knew Ricky and Carmen. And boy, talk about, as Corey Allen, our keyboardist said one time, he says, "Don just flies at a different altitude." And it was true. We would play, we always did "Amazing Grace." And Don was just playing some kind of like tambourine thing on three. But it was great. And his soloing and his whole approach, he was just a fun, fun guy. I love him and I really miss him.

MR: Yeah. That was a shock. Well talk about your songwriting a bit. How do you start?

CF: Sometimes I'll get a title maybe or I'll hear a phrase or something will pop into my head. More often than not I'll hear some kind of little piece of melody or melody and a couple of changes, and then I'll try and develop that. And normally the lyric kind of comes last, oddly enough — or maybe not oddly enough — but that's kind of how I do it. And maybe the greatest thing that came out of my years in Nashville, I lived 4-1/2 years there, and a lot of the songs, they're not maybe harmonically sophisticated. But the storytelling and the lyric is pure genius. And that I always felt was the weakest aspect of my writing. So by going to Nashville I became really aware of telling a story, not wasting the listener's time, and trying to tell it, trying to create musical poetry. And it's still my greatest challenge in songwriting.

MR: Yeah because sometimes you read something and you almost — I could have done that. Well you should have.

CF: Exactly.

MR: It's not —

CF: It's easier — this is one of the amazing things about art to me, is sometimes you hear something and you go yeah, what else could it be. But the genius that it takes to create

that what else could it be is mind-boggling and inspiring. You know, how do I tap into that.

MR: And what's it like trying to get your songs — you're promoting yourself as an artist but then you want to sell your songs or look for a publisher?

CF: Well when I was in Nashville you'd try and get your material to certain artists, if you found out who was looking or producers you would try and network with them or find the most direct route to them. You could hire a song plugger, all of this for a fee mind you. But it's tough, it's tough. Unless you're lucky enough to kind of know the producer, and in Nashville everybody kind of wants a little piece of the pie, which the song is, so I didn't really have any great success there, as a commercial writer. And quite honestly the kind of material I write wasn't a good fit for that market. But as far as marketing, of course now everything's on the web, and we all have our websites and trying to drive people to those sites, that a tough nut to crack. There's so much music out there. It's challenging. I wish I could say I've been incredibly successful at it but I haven't.

MR: Well let's continue that thread about technology. We sometimes think well in the good old days — I'm not sure they were good old days yet it seems like as much as people complain about record companies and stuff, at least there was something to aspire to, and this product would get put out. Now, I'm talking too much, but now it seems like once the product is out there, boom, everybody has it, and how did that happen. And no one paid for it.

CF: Yeah, it's funny. The old paradigm was that there was a kind of a marketing plan via the record companies and their distributors in place. And with that there was a time when they would actually spend money to develop artists and you would be with a label for maybe two or three records, depending on how the deal was structured or whatever, and the record company would be — they had their outlets to get it on the radio, to get radio play, to get the stuff distributed. Of course most of that was coming out of your royalties or whatever. Because they weren't going to give you a free ride. But a whole different paradigm shift now. And I think we're still trying to figure out — especially for recorded music — how to monetize it now. Because unless you're one of the anointed new stars it's going to be tough.

MR: Well let's talk more about, do you recall the most challenging studio date you ever did, or something along that line?

CF: Any time I got called to do a film date. I may have — I tried to keep as cool a demeanor as I could. And I didn't get too many but there was a few along the way. Until you actually see, you walk in and see what's on the stand in front of you, you're kind of thinking okay, I hope this is not like a thousand notes and that there are no changes and that I have to play this thing exactly as written, which turned out I kind of didn't. And the

composers were pretty cool even if the charts were pretty specific they wanted you to make music out of it so they weren't too rigid about that. But you know when you're sitting there with 40 or 50 other musicians on a soundstage at SONY, you don't want to be the one screwing up the take for any reason. Because heads will turn. So those dates were nerve wracking for me. And I can't honestly say I enjoyed it all that much. It was very kind of pressure-packed. And fortunately I didn't hold anyone up, so that worked out okay. But they were tense for me.

MR: Were you hearing a click track?

CF: Yeah. A lot of times, most everything we did was cut to click. So you're trying to interpret this music and play with the drummer and play with the click —

MR: And watch the conductor.

CF: And watch the conductor, and it's challenging.

MR: Do you ever hear things on television or on the radio that you played on?

CF: Yeah. I hear maybe the most played thing that I hear is this theme from this TV show called "Saved by the Bell" which I ended up playing bass on and I also ended up singing the lead vocal and background vocals with a friend of mine, Sunny Wilkinson. So every now and then — it's still being played on cable and it tickles me because we never expected, we didn't know what this was going to be. I happened to know the guy that wrote the theme. He heard me sing at his company's Christmas party. And that's why I got the call to do it, through mutual friends. So I sang the demo for him and then maybe two or three months later he called me up and he said, "Hey man would you be into like we're going to cut this thing and a few other cues for a pilot," so we went out to Bill Schnee's studio and I walk in and Rich Ames, his writing partner, a great keyboard player was playing keyboards. And let's see, Jim Keltner is the drummer, one of my heroes, and so we just start running this and we did, I don't know, maybe 35 cues and the main title. Oh and Dean Parks was playing guitar. So I thought wow, this is a fun date. And the tune was simple, it was fine and Keltner did his beautiful thing on it and everybody played great on it. And then Sunny and I hung around and I sang the theme again. And it was really funny because the NBC suits were behind the glass. So they're getting on the talkback and they're going, "Okay that's great, that's great. Can you make it a little more rock & roll?" So I go like okay. So I try to make it a little more rock & roll. "Well that was great, that was great. Could you enunciate a little more?" But so I just hung in there and they were cool and finally they went click — we got it. And next thing I knew it was on the air. And what was amazing about it is the show went from pilot to a regular show and then a spinoff called "Saved By The Bell, The New Class" was created, which was also running, and they used the same theme. And Sunny Wilkinson, bless her heart, they wanted us to do a buyout, which is just a set fee.

MR: Oh like you're going to get paid for the date.

CF: Yeah you're going to get — "we would like to offer you X amount of dollars for this." And Sunny said to me, she took me aside and said, "Man, we ought to hold out for an after contract in case this thing does go so that we could get residuals on it." So we went to the producer and we said we'd really like an after contract. And they went, fortunately, "no problem." And because of that, and I've written Sunny many times and I said, "Sunny, thank you, thank you for having the smarts and the foresight to just ask that we do this legitimately, not take the buyout, do the after contract. And that show is still paying me some mailbox money every year. It afforded me a little bit of a nice little pension through AFTRA and it blew up worldwide. So in the early 90s I was getting residual checks from it being shown in Italy and all over the planet. It was probably the most lucrative hour and a half of my life. And a complete fluke. I just truly right place, right time. I happened to play a Christmas party where this guy heard me sing "Mustang Sally" or something and remembered my name because he hired the band I was in because he was good friends with the drummer in the band. So he called my friend Doug and Doug gave him my number and the dot is connected and that's how that all went down.

MR: I love those stories because you think about the young musicians now and most of them are going the academic route, and say how do you get a break. Well? Play a Christmas party. You never know what's going to happen.

CF: Exactly. Yes is the most important word I think a musician can have in their vocabulary because you never know. And though you may be tempted to go, like the thing with Christopher, I almost went oh man there's no rehearsal bread there's nothing. I'm so happy I said yeah I'll do it.

MR: You know Phil Woods had a great story about that. He opted just to get the money for the Billy Joel thing with "Just the Way You Are."

CF: Ah, like a buyout?

MR: Or maybe he wasn't even aware of it.

CF: Well, live and learn I guess.

MR: So I have a little — remember the blindfold tests in *DownBeat?*

CF: Sure.

MR: Okay I have a couple of little musical examples here.

[audio interlude]

MR: Ringing a bell?

CF: That's you.

MR: That's you too.

CF: Oh is it really? Oh yeah, is this Chick's Big Band?

MR: The Chick Esposito Big Band.

CF: Oh fantastic. You know I have a reel to reel of this in my tape box that I need to transfer. Oh man. Is this "Ugetsu?"

MR: This is — I can't remember the name of it. It was one of his sort of rock type of — starts with a T — Tam — whatever.

CF: Yeah.

MR: But yeah, that was a fun band. It was a good experience for us. You and I were sort of a little out of the loop with everybody else had a vowel at the end of their name.

CF: Yeah.

MR: You had Esposito and Montalbano and Robilatto. This area had so many great musicians of Italian descent.

CF: Oh man, I can't tell you how much Dick Robilatto, what kind of influence he had on my life. And I was lucky enough that I got him on the phone not too long before he passed away. I'm not even sure he knew for certain who he was talking to. But he said, "Yeah I had a student Charlie who went out to L.A. I think he's doing okay out there." And it was just so touching. He was my high school band director. He was such a wonderful guy. But that's, you know I have said time and time again I feel such a debt to the musicians in Central New York. There's such a rich musical heritage that comes from this area. And many, many great players come from here and I feel lucky to have really grown up here, and I feel that the community here enabled me to go and swim in the L.A. pond. And I'm telling you this now, I've told Carmen [Caramanica], I've told Ricky [Montalbano], if I could tell Sal Amico I would tell him, Chick, Chick knew. Chick — we got together in L.A. one time. He took a trip to L.A. and it was really, really great to see him. Really great to see him.

MR: I've told Rick and Carmen that too. Because when I first moved up here I managed to get a gig with the both of them and Dolores Mancuso at the Beeches. And I just sat on my stool with my sax and I watched and listened to what they did. And I thought I knew a lot because I had gone to music school. But I didn't know anything about playing gigs and filling what people's expectations would be, or beyond. It was really an education for me.

CF: Yeah. Playing here in the years that I did before I went to L.A. was just priceless. And I told Carmen yesterday, because Carmen pulled me in on a project in L.A. before I moved there. It was centered around a percussionist who played in the group Traffic. And his name was Rebop Kwaku Baah. He was a Nigerian prince percussionist. And Carmen had gotten a call from a piano player who was a guy that was Lou Rawls' music director, Reg Powell, and a drummer, Jack Toker, lives in Seattle. And Reg was kind of putting this thing together for Rebop for Island Records or something. So somewhere along the way Carmen said, "hey, I know this bass player guy, I'll bring him with me." So that was my

first trip to L.A. And that was, whoa, eye opening on so many levels. As it turned out Rebop kind of disappeared. So to try and salvage, we had a few days left, two or three days left. Carmen had heard a couple of my original tunes and he says, "why don't you play these for the guys?" So I played three songs of mine. And Reg said, "Let's see if we can get some studio time at Conway Studios." Which is still operating in L.A. We went in and cut three songs. And then we all went home and Reg and a lawyer friend of his started to shop the tape and we got some interest I think from A&M and maybe Reprise or something. And Reg was saying to me, because I was checking in with him, how's it going, and I had already started, I felt the pull of the Pacific. And so he said, "man maybe you want to come out here." And I thought well yeah, maybe so. So I did.

MR: All right. Let me play this.

[audio interlude]

CF: Oh I know what this is. Yeah that's my good friend Mark Hatch.

MR: I love that change right there.

CF: Thank you.

MR: And extended beyond where you thought. I love that.

CF: That's a little tune I wrote called "Country." And I was actually thinking about where I grew up, just outside of Prospect. We had a half mile dirt road from where the bus would drop us off to where our farm was. And I walked down that road many times. And one morning I was just kind of thinking about that and I heard this little melody and these changes, and sketched it out and had this little tune. And one day, Mark Hatch is one of my dearest, dearest best friends. Tremendous flugelhorn/trumpet player. He was busy on the L.A. scene, played with Ray Charles, played with Chaka Khan and Rufus, actually Mark got me on Chaka's gig. And one of the finest players ever. He kind of left the business a long time ago but he never put down the horn. And he has a great jazz group called Route Five, which I played in and still play in from time to time. But I thought okay, let's bring this into rehearsal, and I just wanted to hear it. And the guys played it and it was wonderful. So we did this at a little songwriter night and he was kind enough to come play with me.

MR: Okay. The last blindfold is a lyric. Who wrote, "they say the cause is true, but then again they always do."

CF: Guilty as charged.

MR: The song was "Here We Go."

CF: "Here We Go." And it was my — it seems like my entire lifetime we have been at war with somebody. And after 9/11 I don't know, one day it just occurred to me, oh here we go again. Obviously we didn't ask for that. But I just thought wow, here we go and we don't really know what we're getting into in this deal. And here we are 15, 16 years later,

still at war. So I guess that was kind of my Twenty-First Century "War: What's it good for? Absolutely nothing."

MR: Yeah. Well it's a lovely tune with a strong sentiment.

CF: Thank you.

MR: What's your general outlook on — this is a rather large question — on the state of affairs these days.

CF: Boy, let me think about this for a second. I hope that we are at the beginning of a new paradigm shift and a new awareness is beginning to take place and that we as a nation — this is my opinion — can't be the policeman of the world. We shouldn't be the policeman of the world. I hope that — I'm always hopeful — I still believe all you need is love, everything comes down to love, love, loving, receiving, giving. And though these are challenging, challenging times. I was going to say the answer to this question, catch me on any given day and it might differ. Because some days I'm just like wow, like events yesterday, how can this be? But I'm hopeful that good and loving people will ultimately triumph and that we have to, we cannot live in fear, we cannot become the very thing that we despise. So I'm hopeful that we are that courageous.

MR: Well said.

CF: Thanks. Big question.

MR: We'll lighten it up a little bit. The other day when we were chatting I heard the term "dangling carrot."

CF: Oh man, the dangling carrot. Well we were talking about — my partner Carolyn keeps telling me I should write a book. And about as far as I've gotten on the book is coming up with the title which I thought was *The Dangling Carrot* which is kind of funny because sometimes in the music business it seems like you're just about there, you're just about there and you're going to snap down on this carrot, whatever the carrot might be, and oops, it's over there. But fortunately for me I got to take a few chunks out of the carrot. So I'm grateful and really happy about that. But as you know, and as everybody who's ever been in the business know, it's a challenging way to make a living. Because you never know, you're only as good as your last gig. You never know if you're going to get the next call or when it's going to come. You're hopeful, and I was lucky enough to where I had a nice ride. And I'm still active in the music business but the business has changed and it's very different than it was even ten years ago. And I hate to say it as someone who's played in a lot of pop formats, I'm 63 now and that format is a whole new generation coming up. And I have to consider myself part of the old guard and we're kind of moving to the side, whether we want to or not. And believe me, a lot of the old guard doesn't want to go, they're going down kicking and fighting you know.

MR: Well I was a bit surprised when I started doing these interviews that some of the veteran musicians, who we may have this, the way we think about them is oh, they have it made, they've had their career and they can choose their gigs. Yet those guys were still scrambling. Like "Bring me to your college." They were constantly seeking the next gig. And, but wait, you played with Basie and you played with Ellington. Yeah, but that was 30 years ago.

CF: Absolutely.

MR: It's sobering.

CF: I know so many musicians in L.A. that I so look up to. And I know a lot of guys that are scuffling. You know, that are having a tough go. That have resumes that would be the envy of anyone. And a lot of it is just due to the changes in the business and our ages, now as middle-aged people, especially in L.A. which is a pretty youth-oriented place. And it was good for me when I was twenty, thirty, even forty-something. But it was so funny. I never thought of it in those terms until an incident happened where I realized that I was kind of being replaced because they needed a younger person. It wasn't because I couldn't do the job, it wasn't because they didn't love me, it was because they needed a younger look. And boy that was an ice water over the head moment. Because I just never thought of things in those terms. I thought man if you can play the gig you play the gig. But not always so. All these intangibles. I've always said the music business is the one business that thrives on intangibles. You know. It just thrives on intangibles. But I'm lucky, you know, I've experienced the music business at almost every level — from the sublime to the ridiculous. I know what it's like to be treated better than anyone should ever be treated and I know what it's like to be told to, "Go through the back door, don't talk to the clients, you're not going to be fed on the gig" you know, those kind of things. You know in the sweet moments you really relish them because you know that the curve, kind of like the income curve, you know. It's so funny. One of the things that happened to me was I played a music festival in Charleston, West Virginia with Mike McDonald. I think it was a riverfest. And we were on it and Ray Charles was on it and a bunch of great people. So I think that was a Saturday, we played for like a hundred and twenty thousand people or something like that. So I fly back to L.A. Sunday morning, I'm playing a bar mitzvah Sunday early evening. And we're playing some bossas and some tunes and I've got the tuxedo on in the backyard in Brentwood or someplace. And this kid comes up to me and he goes, "Hey do you guys know any White Snake?" And I said, "No we don't." He goes, "You guys suck." So it was like the night before — so the music business is endlessly humbling.

MR: I'm trying not to laugh. That's really a good story.

CF: Yeah. And I just thought wow, less than 24 hours ago I was playing for 124,000 people that thought we were okay.

MR: Do those gigs, the Chaka Kahn and those things, were you usually paid sort of a salary or were you paid by the gig?

CF: It varied but normally it was like a per week pay. And I guess it all depended. Sometimes it was per show or other times it was like a week's salary. Like if you're out there touring, let's say you're going to be gone six weeks or something like that, if it was a week's salary it was pro rated of course, depending on how many gigs you actually did. They'd break it down into a day rate and then that would be reflected in your check.

MR: I'll bet doing taxes during those years was a bit, of a chore.

CF: Yeah. I didn't attempt it. So I paid the money. Because I'd end up with 1099s and I'd end up with all this different stuff coming in from all these different places. So I had to file all these different schedules, and self-employment tax and this and that. Yeah it got a little complicated.

MR: Do you think you'll ever be tempted to relocate?

CF: I think so. I've lived in the Los Angeles area since 1978, minus 4-1/2 years from '97 to 2003 when I lived in Nashville. And I love California. I have a love affair with the West. California, Washington and Oregon I particularly am fond of. But I think so only because it's — I used to love all the stimulation, everything that was going on there. But now I like a little different pace of life and I kind of feel like I did whatever it was I was supposed to do by going there all those years ago. And I don't feel like I need to be there because the business I once felt I needed to be there for is no longer there. So now we can send files across the 'net and use this technology that also helped destroy the business that we love.

MR: Ironic. Isn't it?

CF: Yeah. But I think we will. I think I'm probably on the last year or two of being in the L.A. metro area, though we love Pasadena. It's a great town. And there's still a lot of great things going on. There's a lot of great music. And that I'll miss. My friends, when we talk about relocating or whatnot, the musician pool is deep and the level of player is high. But you know, as I found from going around the world and going around the planet, there are great players everywhere. And hopefully I'll find them and they'll find me and hopefully we'll learn something from one another.

MR: Well on that note, I will say that there's not an overabundance of fine bassists in the Utica area. So you can keep that in mind. And that little church that you used to go to is still there.

CF: Oh and beautiful as ever. I had a flood of memories coming back, mostly about my mom who passed in ’94. She was only 58. But she was our Unitarian church choir director. So I could feel her there yesterday.

MR: Nice.

CF: It was nice.

MR: Is there anything that you wanted to add that I didn’t ask?

CF: No. Other than to say thank you and I’m flattered and honored to be here. Yeah, it’s really nice.

MR: Yeah. Well you’re in good company. Those people behind you in those notebooks, you’re sharing — some good bass players especially.

CF: Absolutely. No I’m honored to be here, believe me. Honored and humbled.

MR: Okay. Well thanks for your time.

CF: Thank you, Monk, wow, fantastic.

MR: Over and out.